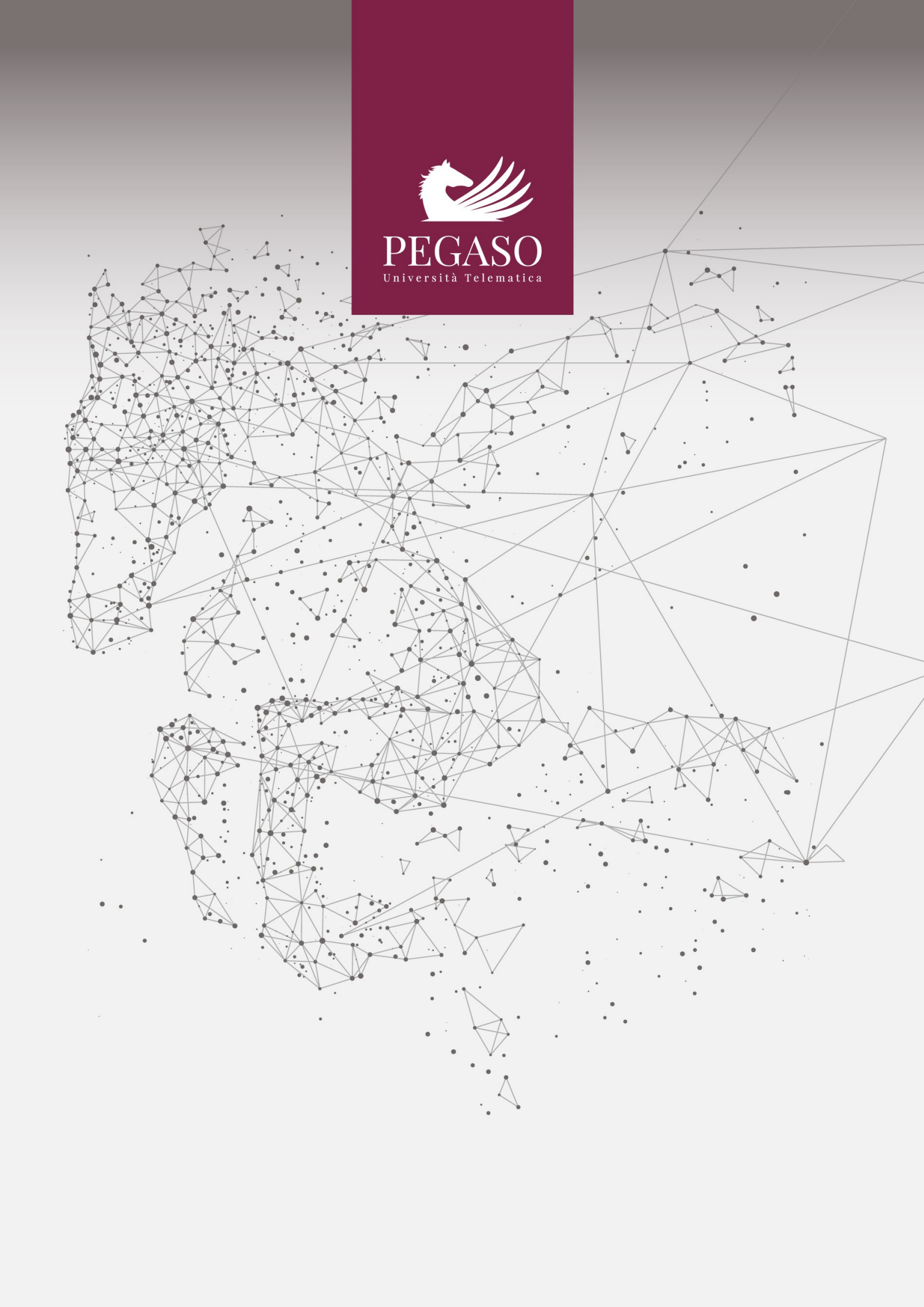

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1. Past simple

Past simple (I did)

Study this example:

Wolfgang Amadeus Mozart was an Austrian musician and composer. He lived from 1756 to 1791. He started composing at the age of five and wrote more than 600 pieces of music. He was only 35 years old when he died.

Lived/started/wrote/was/died are all past simple.

Very often the past simple ends in -ed (regular verbs):

- I work in a travel agency now. Before that I worked in a department store.

- We invited them to our party, but they decided not to come.

- The police stopped me on my way home last night.

- Laura passed her examination because she studied very hard.[1]

Forming the past simple form of regular verbs is quite simple, but there are some spelling rules.

If a verb ends in -e, you add -d.

agree → agreed

like → liked

escape → escaped

If a verb ends in a vowel and a consonant, the consonant is usually doubled before -ed.

stop → stopped

plan → planned

If a verb ends in consonant and -y, you take off the y and add -ied.

try → tried

carry → carried

[1] R. Murphy, *English Grammar in Use Third Edition*, Cambridge, Cambridge University Press, 2004 (6, 11)

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But if the word ends in a vowel and -y, you add -ed.

play → played

enjoy → enjoyed

HOW TO PRONOUNCE -ed AT THE END OF A VERB

There are three different ways to pronounce the 'ed' ending of regular verbs in the simple past tense: /ɪd/, /t/ or /d/.

The pronunciation of the **ed** depends on the sound at the end of the infinitive of the verb.

/ɪd/

This is the least common -ed sound

We use it with words that end in the /t/ or /d/ sounds:

Wanted /'wɒn.tɪd/

Needed /'ni:.dɪd/

Started /stɑ:rtɪd/

Decided /dr'sar.dɪd/

/t/

We use this for words that end in the /p/, /k/, /f/, /s/,/sh/,/ch/ sound:

Watched /wɒtst/

Kissed /kɪst/

Laughed /lɑ:ft/

Asked /ɑ:skt/

Stopped /stɒpt/

/d/

This is the most common -ed sound

We use it with words that end in any other sound:

Saved /servd/

Travelled /'træv.əld/

Opened /'əu.pand/

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Climbed /klaımd/

Closed /klauzd/

But many verbs are irregular. The past simple does not end in -ed. For example:

write → wrote

• Mozart wrote more than 600 pieces of music.

see → saw

• We saw Rose in town a few days ago.

go → went

• I went to the cinema three times last week.

shut → shut

• It was cold, so I shut the window.

In questions and negatives we use did/didn't + infinitive (enjoy/see/go etc.):

Affirmative

I enjoyed the party.

She saw the film

They went home

Interrogative

Did I enjoy the party?

Did she see the film?

Did they go home?

Negative

I didn’t enjoy the party.

She didn’t see the film.

They didn’t go home.

In the following examples, **do** is the main verb in the sentence (did ... do / didn't do):

- What did you do at the weekend? (not What did you at the weekend?)

- I didn't do anything. (not I didn't anything)

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The past of be (am/is/are) is was/were:

I/he/she/it was/wasn't

was 1/he/she/it?

we/you/they were/weren't

were we/you/they?

Note that we do not use **did** in negatives and questions with was/were:

-I was angry because they were late.

- Was the weather good when you were on holiday?

- They weren't able to come because they were so busy.

- Did you go out last night or were you too tired?[2]

[2] R. Murphy, *English Grammar in Use Third Edition*, Cambridge, Cambridge University Press, 2004 (6, 11)

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2. Past Continuous

Past continuous

Study this example situation:

Yesterday Karen and Jim played tennis. They began at 10 o'clock and finished at 11.30. So, at 10.30 they were playing tennis.

They were playing = they were in the middle of
playing. They had not finished playing.

Was/were -ing is the past continuous;

I/he/she/it was doing
we/you/they were playing

I was doing something = I was in the middle of doing something at a certain time. The action or situation had already started before this time, but had not finished:

- This time last year I was living in Brazil.
- What were you doing at 10 o'clock last night?
- I waved to Helen, but she wasn't looking.

Compare the past continuous (I was doing) and past simple (I did):

Past continuous (in the middle of an action)

Past simple (complete action)

• I was walking home when I met Dave. (in the middle of an action)

• I walked home after the party last night. = all the way, completely)

• Kate was watching television when we arrived.

• Kate watched television a lot when she was ill last year.

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We often use the past simple and the past continuous together to say that something happened in the middle of something else.

- Matt phoned while we were having dinner.
- It was raining when I got up.
- I saw you in the park yesterday. You were sitting on the grass and reading a book.
- I hurt my back while I was working in the garden.

But we use the past simple to say that one thing happened after another:

• I was walking along the road when I saw Dave. So I stopped, and we had a chat.

Compare:

• When Karen arrived, we were having dinner. (= we had already started before she arrived)

• When Karen arrived, we had dinner. (= Karen arrived, and then we had dinner)

Some verbs (for example, know and want) are not normally used in the continuous:

-We were good friends. We knew each other well. (not We were knowing)

- I was enjoying the party, but Chris wanted to go home. (not was wanting)[3]

[3] R. Murphy, *English Grammar in Use Third Edition*, Cambridge, Cambridge University Press, 2004 (6, 11)

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3. Past Simple vs. Past Continuous

Past simple and past continuous

We use both the past simple and the past continuous to talk about situations and events in the past.

We use the past simple for:

- a short, completed action

  He opened the car door.

- a sequence of actions

  He opened the door, got out and walked towards the animal.

  We use the past continuous for:

- an unfinished or continuing activity

  He was trying to switch on his camera.

  The lion was looking at them.

- a background situation

  It was raining and the trees were blowing in the wind.

Take Note: that we don't use the past continuous with state verbs, such as like, love, need, own, want.

We often use the past continuous and the past simple in the same sentence to talk about two things that happened at the same time. We often use when and while to link the two events in sentences like this.

They were driving home when they heard a strange noise.

We got lost while we were walking in the jungle.

We normally put when and while in the middle of the sentence. If we want to emphasize the first part of the sentence, when and while can go at the beginning.

Remember to use a comma (,) in the middle of the sentence when this happens.

While we were walking in the jungle, we got lost.

We don't normally use while with the past simple, but you can use when with the past continuous.

I was swimming in the sea when I saw a dolphin. (not I was swimming in the sea while I saw a dolphin.)

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When I was driving home, I heard a strange noise. (or While I was driving home,...)

We often make questions in the past continuous to ask about activities at the time of a key event.

What were you doing when you first saw the shark?

We often make questions in the past simple to ask about actions after a key event.

What did you do when the shark swam away?[4]

Exercises

Complete the sentences using the following verbs in the correct form:

buy

catch

cost

fall

hurt

sell

spend

teach

write*

Ex. Mozart. wrote* more than 600 pieces of music.

1. How did you learn to drive?' 'My father .....me.

2. We couldn't afford to keep our car, so we …….. it.

3. Dave…….down the stairs this morning and ….. his leg.

4 Jim threw the ball to Sue, who …… it.

5. Ann …….a lot of money yesterday. She …….a dress which……£100.

You ask James about his holiday. Write your questions for him.

Hi. How are things? Fine, thanks. I've just had a great holiday.

Ex. Where ....did you go ?

To the U.S. We went on a trip from San Francisco to Denver.

6. How .,…….? By car?

Yes, we hired a car in San Francisco.

7. It's a long way to drive. How long……..? Two weeks.

[4] H. Stephenson, J. Hughes, P. Dummett, *Life Intermediate Student Book Second Edition*, Hampshire, National Geographic Learning, 2019 (160)

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8. Where ……? In hotels? Yes, small hotels or motels.

9. ……? Yes, but it was very hot - sometimes too hot.

10. …….the Grand Canyon? Of course. It was wonderful.

Complete the sentences. Put the verb into the correct form, positive or negative

11. It was warm, so I …... off my coat. (take)

12. The film wasn't very good. I ..... it very much. (enjoy)

13. knew Sarah was very busy, so I …… her. (disturb)

14. I was very tired, so I ……the party early. (leave)

15. The bed was very uncomfortable. I .. very well. (sleep)

16. The window was open and a bird ……into the room. (fly)

17. The hotel wasn't very expensive. It .. very much. (cost)

Put the verb into the correct form, past continuous or past simple.

Ex. Jenny. was waiting... (wait) for me when I. arrived (arrive).

18. What ……(you / do) at this time yesterday?' 'I was asleep.'

19. ……(you / go) out last night? 'No, I was too tired."

20. How fast ……..(you / drive) when the accident…….(happen)?

21. Sam …….(take) a photograph of me while ……(not / look).

22.We were in a very difficult position. We …….(not / know) what to do.

23. I haven't seen Alan for ages. When I last …….(see) him, he …….(try) to find a job.

24. …… (walk) along the street when suddenly I (hear) footsteps behind me. Somebody ……(follow) me. I was scared and I …….(start) to run.[5]

Translate the following text into Italian.

25. The team was making its way up the great cliff. While the climbers were moving up the rather steep rock face, the sun moved out from behind its summit. This shift in sunlight created a problem for most of the team who found themselves struggling with the intense light both directly in their eyes and in reflection off the stone. It was a relief when they each reached the top safely and were able to descend easily.

[5] R. Murphy, *English Grammar in Use Third Edition*, Cambridge, Cambridge University Press, 2004 (6, 11)

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Exercise answer key

1. My father taught me.
2. So we sold it.
3. David fell down the stairs this morning and broke his leg.
4. Jim threw the ball to Sue, who caught it.
5. Anne spent a lot of money yesterday. She bought a dress which cost 100 pounds.
6. How did you go?
7. How long did it take?
8. Where did you stay?
9. Was the weather good?
10. Did you visit the Grand Canyon?
11. So I took off my coat.
12. I didn't enjoy it very much.
13. I didn't disturb her.
14. I left the party early.
15. I didn't sleep very well.
16. A bird flew into the room.
17. It didn't cost very much.
18. What were you doing at this time yesterday?
19. Did you go out last night?
20. How fast were you driving when the accident happened?
21. Sam took a photograph of me while I wasn't looking.
22. We didn't know what to do.
23. When I last saw him, he was trying to find a job.
24. I was walking along the street when suddenly I heard footsteps behind me. Somebody was following me. I was scared and I started to run.
25. La squadra stava risalendo la grande scarpata. Mentre gli scalatori salivano sulla parete rocciosa piuttosto ripida, il sole è uscito da dietro la sua cima. Questo spostamento della luce solare ha creato un problema per la maggior parte della squadra che si è trovata a fronteggiare sia la luce intensa direttamente negli occhi che quella riflessa dalla pietra. È stato un sollievo quando ognuno di loro ha raggiunto la cima sano e salvo ed è stato in grado di scendere facilmente.

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